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ARTICLE

The First Space War Could Be Closer Than You Think

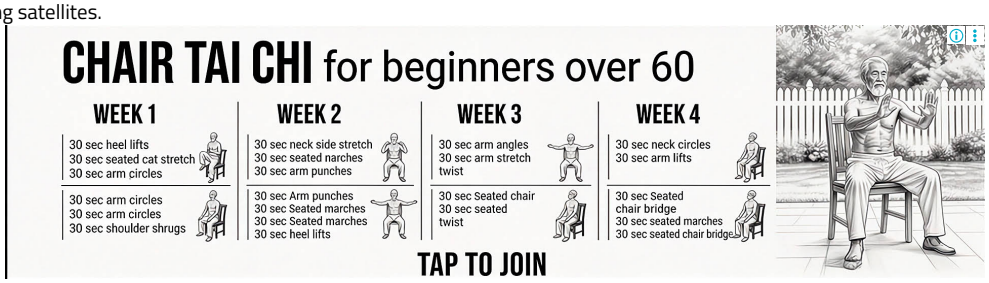


BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 19, 2026

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British experts have warned that conflict in space could emerge within five years. The warning came as Britain's space industry shifts toward defense: companies founded to remove orbital debris or refuel spacecraft are now working on military capabilities, and the Royal Air Force has formed a squadron dedicated to defending satellites.



The United States has acknowledged deploying weapons in orbit. China is practicing close approaches and satellite capture. Russia has maneuvered a military satellite close to ICEYE-X36, a commercial radar satellite whose technology supports Ukraine.

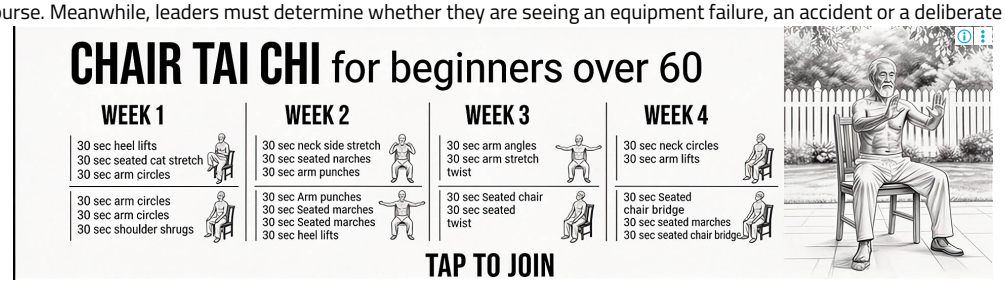
These are not disconnected headlines. They are signs that the world's leading powers are preparing for a fight over the systems circling above us—and that the first move may already look like the one unfolding now.



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A space war would not have to begin with an explosion. It could begin with a signal jammed, a satellite camera blinded, a spacecraft pushed off course or a communications link cut. A cyberattack on a ground station could sever the connection between a satellite and the people who operate it.

The first signs might look like scattered failures. GPS becomes unreliable. A military unit loses contact. A radar satellite stops sending images. A spacecraft suddenly changes course. Meanwhile, leaders must determine whether they are seeing an equipment failure, an accident or a deliberate attack.



That confusion is part of the danger. An adversary can disrupt a satellite without announcing war, then watch to see how its target responds. A country that waits may appear weak. A country that strikes back may turn a limited attack into a wider conflict.

From GPS to the Gas Pump

Satellites help aircraft navigate, guide ships and trucks, track severe weather and coordinate emergency response. Farmers use satellite navigation to guide precision equipment across fields. First responders use location data to find the fastest route to an emergency. Military forces depend on satellite images, communications and navigation to coordinate operations.

GPS also provides precise timing for systems on the ground. Telecommunications networks use that timing to keep signals coordinated. Power companies rely on synchronized measurements to monitor the grid. Financial networks use accurate timestamps to process transactions.



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A disruption would not flip one switch and plunge the entire country into darkness. It could create failures across systems people take for granted. Cell service could become less reliable. Deliveries could be delayed. Emergency crews might have less accurate location data. Banks and businesses could struggle with timing and communications disruptions.

Even filling the car could become harder. A gas pump needs power and a working connection to process a card payment. If the station's network goes down, the pump may be unable to authorize a purchase. Many stations connect through terrestrial networks such as cable, fiber or cellular service.

Remote stations that use satellite broadband could lose that connection if satellite communications were disrupted. A GPS outage alone would not shut down every gas pump, but a wider attack on communications could leave some stations unable to take cards or restock efficiently.

The effects would spread beyond the pump. Trucks need fuel to move food, medicine and supplies. If navigation, communications or payment systems falter across a region, the pressure travels through the supply chain—to the store, the pharmacy and the emergency room.

The Nuclear Threat Above Earth

The most frightening possibility is a nuclear weapon in orbit. U.S. intelligence has warned that Russia is developing a nuclear anti-satellite capability and has raised concerns about the Russian satellite Cosmos 2553. A nuclear deton space could damage large numbers of satellites and make valuable orbits

That would not be a weapon aimed at one target. It could cripple systems used by the attacker, its enemies and neutral countries alike. A single act could blind militaries, disrupt communications and leave the world struggling to replace essential orbital infrastructure.

A Test of How Far the World Will Go

NATO has said an attack in, from or within space could lead to Article 5. The alliance would assess the circumstances, including the target, the damage and the evidence of responsibility. No adversary should assume an attack in orbit would be treated as a minor incident.

The arms race itself is adding to the danger. Each nation calls its new capabilities defensive. Each rival sees a growing threat and prepares its own answer. A spacecraft able to inspect or repair a satellite can also threaten it. A system built to interfere with an enemy's signal can disrupt more than its intended target.

That is how an arms race accelerates: each side prepares for the threat it sees, and each new capability gives the other side another reason to prepare.

Russia's maneuver near ICEYE-X36 brings this danger into focus. Satellites that once seemed remote and secure are being approached, watched and tested. The next move could be another warning. It could also force governments to decide whether to respond.

The coming space war may unfold through close approaches, lost signals and sudden failures. Most people will not see the first move. They may notice only when the systems they rely on begin to break down.

Space is no longer safely above the conflicts on Earth. It is woven into them—and the price of losing access could be paid at the gas pump, in the delivery network, in the emergency room and on the battlefield.

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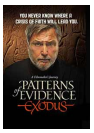
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